

A is for Archive

A Regina Russo Mystery

The Alphabet Series • Book 1

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For Mom

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Chapter 1

I Don't Take Estate Cases Anymore

The espresso pot gurgled its last breath at 6:47 AM. I poured the final cup into my favorite mug — the one that says "World's Okayest Grandma" in chipped letters — and sat down at the kitchen table.

Paperclip jumped onto the chair beside me. Orange tabby, twenty-two pounds of pure judgment. He stared at me like I'd made a life choice he didn't approve of. Which, knowing him, I probably had.

"I'm retired," I told him. "I don't take cases anymore. Especially not estate cases."

Paperclip blinked. Slow. Disapproving.

The phone rang.

I let it go to voicemail. Nobody good calls before seven. My ex-husband knew better. My kids knew I was useless before coffee. The cops who used to be my partners knew I'd hung up my badge three years ago.

The machine beeped. A woman's voice, older, steady, the kind of voice that had spent decades shushing children in libraries.

"Ms. Russo? My name is Dorothy Chen. I was told you're the person to see when you need something found. It's about my sister's things. She passed last month. There's a box — I don't know what to do with it. Please call me back."

She left a number. I wrote it on the back of a grocery list. Milk. Eggs. Bread. Luca's asthma inhaler.

I looked at Paperclip.

"Estate cases," I said. "Always estate cases. People die, they leave things, their families don't know what to do with the weight."

Paperclip yawned. He'd heard this before.

I don't take estate cases anymore. Not since the thing with the Vargas family. Not since I found what I found and had to decide what to do with it. Not since I learned that some boxes

shouldn't be opened, and some shouldn't be closed.

But Dorothy Chen's voice had something in it. Not grief. Not exactly. Something older. The sound of someone who'd been carrying a secret too long and finally needed to set it down.

I drank my espresso. It was cold.

I picked up the phone.

#

Chapter 2

The Librarian's Box

Dorothy Chen answered on the first ring, like she'd been sitting by the phone since her voicemail cut off.

"Ms. Russo?"

"Regina, please. You said you needed something found."

A pause. Not hesitation — the kind of pause you make when you're deciding whether to trust someone with a thing you've carried too long.

"I have a box. My sister Eleanor's box. She passed in March. The funeral home gave it to me, but... I don't know what's in it. I haven't opened it."

"Why me?"

"Your name came up. At the library. Someone said you're the person who finds things other people can't."

I used to be a lot of things. Cop. Investigator. The woman they called when the warrant came back cold and the captain still wanted answers. Now I'm the grandmother who picks up grandkids from school and makes sauce on Sundays. But old names stick.

"What kind of box?"

"Small. Metal. Like a lockbox, but not bank-issue. It was in her desk. She kept it locked. I have the key."

"And you want me to..."

"Tell me what's in it. Tell me if I should burn it. Tell me if it matters."

I wrote down the address. Harbor View Public Library, Cypress Point branch. Eleanor Chen had worked there thirty-two years, retired five years ago. Dorothy still volunteered in the children's room. Same building, different floor.

"I'll come by tomorrow. Morning."

"Ten o'clock. I'll be at the circulation desk."

###

The library smelled like paper and floor wax and the particular quiet that only exists in places where people have agreed, collectively, to lower their voices. I showed up at 9:47. Early enough to seem serious. Late enough to seem like I had other places to be.

Dorothy Chen was smaller than her voice. Seventies, maybe older. Gray hair pulled back in a bun that had been tight thirty years ago and had learned to forgive gravity. She wore a cardigan despite the California morning. Librarians always look cold, even in summer.

"Ms. Russo. Thank you for coming."

"Regina."

She nodded. Led me through the stacks. Past the fiction shelves. Past the periodicals. Up a flight of stairs to a door marked STAFF ONLY. Her office was small. A desk. A filing cabinet. A photograph of two women — younger versions of Dorothy and someone who looked enough like her to be a twin. Eleanor.

Dorothy opened the bottom drawer of her desk. Lifted out a box.

It was metal. Gunmetal gray. About the size of a shoebox. No markings. No label. Just a small keyhole on the front and the weight of something that had been kept secret for a long time.

"She told me once," Dorothy said, "that if anything happened to her, I should give this to you. But she made me promise not to open it myself."

"When was this?"

"Two years ago. She was already sick then. Pancreatic. They caught it late."

I took the box. It was heavier than it looked. Not metal-heavy. Paper-heavy. The kind of weight that comes from documents stacked tight.

"You haven't opened it."

"I told you. She made me promise."

"People make dying relatives promise a lot of things. Most of them are about keeping secrets buried."

Dorothy looked at me. Not angry. Not defensive. Just tired.

"Eleanor and I were close. Closer than most sisters. If she didn't want me to open this, there was a reason. I'd rather know the reason and live with it than open it and spend the rest of my life wondering why she asked."

I'd heard that speech before. Variations of it. The part where someone tries to convince themselves that not knowing is a form of respect. Sometimes it is. Sometimes it's just fear with better branding.

"I'll call you when I know something."

"Ms. Russo — Regina — whatever's in there... it's not normal. Eleanor was a librarian. She catalogued things. She filed things. She didn't hide things."

"Until she did."

Dorothy didn't answer. She walked me back to the circulation desk. I put the box in my tote bag. It sat there, against my hip, like a second heartbeat.

###

I drove home. Parked in the driveway. Carried the box inside.

Paperclip was on the kitchen table. He looked at the box. He looked at me. He made a sound in his throat that cats make when they've decided something is beneath them.

"I know," I said. "Estate cases."

I set the box on the table. Next to the espresso pot. Next to the grocery list with Dorothy's number on the back.

I didn't open it.

Not yet.

First I made coffee. First I sat down. First I let the box exist in the room without me pretending I was ready for what it would say.

Luca called at 10:23. His inhaler was acting up again. The school nurse wanted to know if I could pick up a refill. I said yes. I wrote it on the list. Milk. Eggs. Bread. Luca's asthma inhaler.

The box sat there.

Paperclip put his head on his paws. He closed his eyes. He was waiting. He knew I'd open it eventually. He knew I'd find something I couldn't unfind.

He's always right about these things.

I finished my coffee.

I picked up the key.

Chapter 3

Letters from 1947

The key turned smooth. Eleanor Chen had kept the lock oiled. Someone who hides things still wants them to open easily when the time comes.

Inside: envelopes. Twelve of them. Yellowed. No stamps. No addresses. Just dates on the front, in a handwriting that matched the photograph on Dorothy's desk.

1947. All of them.

I pulled out the first one. Unfolded the paper. The ink had faded to the color of old tea.

###

March 15, 1947 Harbor View, California

Dear Tom,

I don't know if you'll ever read this. Eleanor says I'm being paranoid. She says the war is over and men like you are safe now. But I saw what they did to the Tanakas next door. One day they were running the fish market. The next day they were on a bus to Manzanar with a number on their coat.

The property on Cypress Point — the waterfront lot we talked about — it's not mine anymore. I signed the papers. Not because I wanted to. Because the man from the holding company said it would be better for everyone if I didn't fight.

His name was Walter P. Sheridan. He works for Pacific Meridian Holdings. He said the property would be used for "defense purposes." He said it was patriotic to cooperate.

I know what that word means now. It means sign or lose everything.

The deed is in the box. The one with the date you gave me. March 3, 1947. That's when they recorded it. But I never went to the title company. I never signed in front of a notary. Sheridan just took it.

If you're reading this, I'm probably gone. Take care of Dorothy. And if you ever come back to Harbor View, tell someone what they did. Not for me. For the Tanakas. For everyone who got on that bus.

Your friend, Helen

###

I read it twice. Then I read it again.

The Tanakas. Manzanar. Cypress Point.

I know Cypress Point. It's the most expensive waterfront in Harbor View now. Gated community. Private security. You can't even see the ocean unless you live there.

I pulled out the deed. It was there, just like Helen said. Dated March 3, 1947. Signature: Helen Kato. Notary seal: *Pacific Meridian Title Company*. Witness: Walter P. Sheridan.

I'd seen that name before. Not Helen. Not Tom. Walter P. Sheridan.

I got up. Went to my desk. Opened the filing cabinet in the corner where I keep the old cases. The ones I said I'd quit.

Pulled the Vargas file.

Three years ago. A family lost their house. Not to foreclosure. To a holding company that produced a deed from 1952. The holding company: Pacific Meridian Holdings. The witness on that deed: Walter P. Sheridan.

Same name. Same company. Forty-five years apart.

I went back to the kitchen. Sat down. Paperclip opened one eye. He knew I'd found something.

"Helen Kato," I said. "Tom. Dorothy's sister Eleanor. They were close. Closer than most sisters."

Dorothy had said that. About her and Eleanor.

I picked up the phone. Called Ray Delgado. He used to be my partner at Harbor View PD before he made lieutenant and I made the decision to leave.

"Regina." He sounded tired. "You retired. Remember? You're not supposed to call me about cases."

"I need you to run a name."

"Off the books?"

"Yeah."

"Who am I looking for?"

"Walter P. Sheridan. Born maybe 1910s, 1920s. Last known working for Pacific Meridian Holdings. Might be dead. Might not."

"Pacific Meridian. That's the defense contractor?"

"That's the one."

"Regina. You said you were done."

"I am."

"You don't sound done."

I looked at the box. At the eleven remaining envelopes. At the deed that shouldn't exist, signed by a woman who'd been forced to give up property she owned.

"Ray. Just run the name."

He sighed. The sound a man makes when he knows he's going to do the thing he said he wouldn't.

"I'll call you back."

He hung up. I sat there. Paperclip stretched. He put his paw on the box. Like he was claiming it.

"Estate cases," I said. "I told you. I don't take estate cases anymore."

Paperclip yawned. He didn't believe me either.

Chapter 4

Paperclip Judges

Ray called back at 2:14 PM. I was making lunch. Grilled cheese. Tomato soup. The kind of meal that doesn't require thinking.

"Your Walter P. Sheridan died in 1989," he said. No hello. That's Ray.

"Cause of death?"

"Natural causes. Cardiac arrest. He was seventy-eight."

"Any kids?"

"One daughter. Patricia Sheridan. Now Patricia Sheridan-Vargas."

The name hit me like a slap.

"Vargas? As in—"

"As in the family you investigated three years ago. The ones who lost their house to Pacific Meridian Holdings. Patricia Vargas is the current CEO. Her maiden name is Sheridan. Walter P. Sheridan's daughter."

I sat down. The phone felt heavy.

"Ray. You're telling me the same holding company that took Helen Kato's property in 1947 is still operating. And the woman who runs it now is the daughter of the man who signed that deed."

"I'm telling you Pacific Meridian Holdings is still active. I'm telling you Patricia Sheridan-Vargas is the CEO. I'm telling you her father died in '89 and she took over the company in '92. The Vargas file you pulled — that was 2023. This Helen Kato letter — that's 1947. That's a seventy-five-year pattern, Regina."

Patterns I know. I've seen them. The swamp doesn't drain. It just grows new weeds.

"Did you tell anyone you was looking into this?"

"No. You said off the books."

"Good. Keep it that way."

"Regina. Be careful. Pacific Meridian has lawyers. They have connections. They have a reason to not want old deeds dug up."

"I'm just a grandmother, Ray. I make sauce. I pick up my grandkids from school. What are they going to do to me?"

He didn't laugh. Neither did I.

###

After I hung up, I sat at the kitchen table for a long time. The box was still there. Eleven envelopes left.

Paperclip jumped onto my lap. He's twenty-two pounds. When he decides you need him, he doesn't ask. He put his head on my hand. Looked at me with those orange cat eyes that have seen me at my worst and decided I was worth staying for anyway.

"What do you think, buddy?"

He blinked. Slow. The way cats do when they've heard your whole speech and decided it's not worth a meow.

"I know. I said I was done. But Helen Kato wrote that letter and put it in a box and gave it to her sister and made her promise to wait. That's not just hiding something. That's hoping someone will find it."

Paperclip stretched. He put his paw on the box again.

"Yeah. I know. You're right. I'm already in."

Luca called again at 3:00. His inhaler refill was ready at the pharmacy. Could I pick it up? I said yes. I wrote it on the list. Milk. Eggs. Bread. Luca's asthma inhaler.

I looked at the box. At the deed. At the letter from a woman who watched her neighbors get taken away and knew her turn was next.

Three hundred dollars a month. That's what Luca's inhaler costs. The patent is owned by a company called Alerion Pharmaceuticals. Alerion is owned by a holding company. The holding company is owned by Pacific Meridian Holdings.

I didn't know that before today. I found out when I looked.

Paperclip judged me. He always does.

"I'm not doing this for the case," I told him. "I'm doing this because a kid needs medicine and a woman wrote a letter and nobody listened."

Paperclip closed his eyes. He didn't believe me. He knows me better than I know myself.

I picked up the second envelope.

Chapter 5

The Property on Cypress Point

I drove to Cypress Point at 4:30 PM. Not too late. Not too early. The kind of time when people are still at work and the gates are less careful about who comes through.

The entrance is off Cypress Drive. You turn left past the gas station. Right at the stop sign. Left again at the little park with the statue of some founder I never learned the name of. The gate is white. Wrought iron. A camera mounted on the left post.

I rolled down my window.

"Can I help you?" The guard was maybe fifty. Uniform that fit too well. The kind of guy who used to be a cop and got tired of the pay.

"Just looking for a friend. 47 Cypress."

He looked at me. I looked like what I am: a grandmother in a Toyota with a tote bag and a list of errands I didn't finish.

"47 is that way." He pointed. "You'll need to park in the visitor lot. Second turn on the left."

"Thank you."

He didn't ask for ID. Didn't ask me to sign in. The camera was there, but I don't think it was recording. It's the kind of security that looks like security but is really just a gate.

I drove through.

###

The houses on Cypress Point are the kind of houses you don't buy with mortgages. They're bought with holding companies. They're bought with wire transfers. They're bought with money that doesn't need to explain where it came from.

I parked in the visitor lot. Got out. Walked.

47 Cypress Point was white. Three stories. A balcony that faced the ocean. A driveway that could fit four cars. The kind of house that costs more in property tax than I made in thirty years of work.

I stood on the sidewalk. Looked at the house. Looked at the ocean behind it.

Helen Kato wrote that letter from a house that used to stand here. Or maybe she wrote it from a smaller house. A fisherman's cottage. The kind of place people like her and Tom could afford before the war, before the camps, before the holding companies came.

A woman walked her dog past me. Poodle. Expensive collar.

"Beautiful view," she said.

"It is."

"You thinking of buying?"

"Just looking."

She smiled. The kind of smile people give you when they know you can't afford what they're selling.

"Most of these houses were built in the nineties. Before that, there were just a few old cottages. The Tanaka place was here. And the Kato house. They sold in the forties. Moved inland."

She kept walking. The dog trotted beside her.

I stood there. Wrote down what she said. Tanaka. Kato. Forties.

The Tanakas got on a bus to Manzanar. Helen Kato signed a deed she never wanted to sign. Walter P. Sheridan witnessed it for Pacific Meridian Holdings.

Seventy-five years later, his daughter runs the same company. Owns the same property. Charges three hundred a month for the inhaler that keeps my grandson breathing.

I took a picture of the house. Not the whole house. Just the corner where the mailbox would be. Just the street sign that said 47 CYPRESS POINT in black letters on white background.

Evidence. Not for a case. For myself. So I could remember what I saw when I drove away.

Paperclip was right. I'm already in.

I got back in the car. Drove home. There were nine more envelopes in the box. I hadn't opened them yet.

Some boxes shouldn't be opened. Helen Kato knew that. She wrote the letter anyway.

Chapter 6

Maeve Knows Somebody

I stopped by my mother's house on the way home. She lives six blocks from me. Same house she's lived in since 1974. Same neighbors. Same rose bushes that bloom when they want to and not a day before.

Maeve Russo is seventy-eight. She knows everyone's business. She has zero filter. She's the reason I got into this work in the first place — she knew a woman whose husband disappeared and the cops weren't looking hard enough and I was the one she called.

I pulled into her driveway. She was on the porch. Waiting.

"You look like hell," she said.

"Nice to see you too, Ma."

"Come inside. I made coffee."

The house smelled like garlic and oregano and the particular scent of old wood that's been lived in for fifty years. Maeve sat down at the kitchen table. I sat across from her.

"What's wrong?"

"I'm looking into something. I need to know if you remember Helen Kato."

Maeve's face changed. Not a lot. Just the way a face changes when a name from the past walks back into the room.

"Helen Kato. Sure I remember her. She worked at the library. Her sister too. Dorothy still does."

"Helen died in March. She left a box. Letters from 1947. Property on Cypress Point. A man named Walter Sheridan from Pacific Meridian Holdings."

Maeve was quiet for a long time. Then she got up. Went to the drawer where she keeps the takeout menus. Came back with a pen. Wrote a name on the back of a Chinese food menu.

"Frank Delgado. Ray's uncle. He's eighty-two. He worked at the title company in the forties. Pacific Meridian Title. He was there when Sheridan came in with that deed."

"Ma. Why do you know this?"

"Because Helen came to me. In 1947. She was scared. She didn't know who to talk to. I was younger. I thought I could help. I couldn't."

"You never told me."

"You were a kid. Then you were a cop. Then you were... whatever you are now. When would I have told you?"

I don't know the answer to that. There's never a good time to tell your daughter that a woman was forced off her property and there was nothing anyone could do.

"Can I talk to Frank?"

"He doesn't talk much anymore. Stroke took his words. But he remembers. And he writes."

She picked up the phone. Dialed. Waited.

"Frank? It's Maeve. Yeah. No, I'm good. You? Listen — Regina. My daughter. She's asking about Helen Kato. Yeah. That Helen. She found the box. The letters. Yeah."

She held out the phone.

"He wants to talk to you."

I took the phone.

"Mr. Delgado?"

"Regina. Maeve's girl. You're the one who found the box."

"I did."

"Helen was a good woman. She didn't deserve what happened."

"Can you tell me what you saw?"

"I saw the deed. I saw Sheridan's signature. I saw Helen's name. But I never saw Helen sign it. That's the thing. I worked that counter for thirty years. I saw a lot of deeds. Helen Kato never walked into that office."

"Someone forged her signature."

"Or Sheridan brought in a paper and said it was done. Back then? Who's going to say no to a man like that? He had the company. He had the connections. He had the war behind him and the cold war in front. Japanese families coming back from the camps? They didn't have a chance."

I wrote it down. Every word.

"Frank. Why now? Why did Helen wait fifty years to tell someone?"

"Because she was waiting for someone who would listen. Her sister was too young. Her husband was dead. The cops? The lawyers? They all knew Sheridan. She needed someone outside. Someone who didn't owe him anything."

"Like me."

"Like you."

I hung up. Sat there. Maeve poured me more coffee.

"You're in deep on this one," she said.

"Yeah."

"Be careful. Men like Sheridan don't raise daughters to run companies without teaching them how to protect what they have."

"Patricia Sheridan-Vargas. She's the CEO now."

Maeve nodded. "I know who she is. Everyone in Harbor View knows. She gives money to the right causes. She sits on the right boards. She's the kind of woman people trust."

"Based on what?"

"Based on the fact that she's never had to take no for an answer."

I finished my coffee. Put the Chinese food menu in my tote bag. Next to the grocery list. Next to Dorothy's number.

"Thanks, Ma."

"Regina."

I turned.

"Bring the grandkids by Sunday. I haven't seen them in a week."

"I will."

"And don't forget the inhaler."

I didn't forget. Milk. Eggs. Bread. Luca's asthma inhaler.

I drove home. Nine envelopes left. Frank Delgado's words in my notebook. A property I can't afford to look at. A company that owns the medicine my grandson needs.

Paperclip was on the porch. Waiting. He knew I'd be back. He knew I'd keep going.

He's always right about these things.

Chapter 7

The Title Company

Pacific Meridian Title Company still exists. Of course it does. The address is downtown. Fourth and Cypress. A building that looks like it was built to last forever.

I walked in at 9:15 AM. The lobby smelled like marble and money. The kind of place where people don't ask why you're here — they assume you have a reason and they'll find out what it is.

"I'm looking for records," I told the woman at the desk. "Property transfers. 1947. Cypress Point waterfront."

She was maybe forty. Blazer. Name tag: *Nancy*. The kind of receptionist who's been told everything and forgotten nothing.

"Do you have a parcel number?"

"No."

"Owner name?"

"Helen Kato. Or Helen Chen. She might have used both."

Nancy typed. Looked at the screen. Typed again.

"We don't have physical records from 1947. Those were transferred to the county archive in '89. You'll need to go to the recorder's office."

"What about Pacific Meridian Holdings? Do you still handle their transfers?"

Her face changed. Not a lot. Just the way a face changes when you've asked a question that has an answer someone doesn't want to give.

"I can't help you with that."

"I'm not asking for current records. Just old ones."

"Ma'am. I don't have access to archives. You need to go to the county recorder."

I wrote down the address she gave me. County recorder's office. Government building. Concrete. The kind of place where records go to be stored and never looked at.

"Thank you."

She didn't say you're welcome. She watched me walk away. Made a phone call after I hit the door. I could hear it through the glass. One word. Just once.

"Kato."

###

The county recorder's office is on Grand Avenue. Basement level. You go down a flight of stairs. The air is cooler down there. Paper lives better in the cold.

The clerk was a man who looked like he'd been working there since the records were new. Maybe he had.

"1947?" He looked at me over his glasses. "That's microfilm. You'll need to pull the reels yourself. We don't have staff for that."

"Where are the reels?"

"Back wall. Cypress Point is reel 47-C. Sign in first."

I signed. Gave him my license. He handed me a key.

"Reel 47-C. Reader is in the corner. Don't crease the film."

The microfilm reader is the kind of machine that hasn't changed since 1970. Big screen. Hand crank. The kind of technology that outlasts everything because it doesn't need to be updated.

I found the reel. Put it on the machine. Started cranking.

Deeds. Transfers. Mortgages. The paper trail of a town changing hands.

March 3, 1947. There it was.

Grantor: Helen Kato. Grantee: Pacific Meridian Holdings. Property: 47 Cypress Point, Harbor View, CA. Consideration: \$1.00 and other valuable consideration.

One dollar. That's what they paid. One dollar and "other valuable consideration" — the phrase lawyers use when they don't want to say what was actually exchanged.

I looked at the signature. Helen Kato. It looked like her handwriting from the letters. But I'd seen that handwriting under pressure. I'd seen what it looked like when someone is afraid.

I cranked further. Found the notarization. *Notary Public: Walter P. Sheridan. Commission expires: December 31, 1947.*

Sheridan wasn't just the witness. He was the notary. He witnessed his own document.

That's not just irregular. That's not allowed. A notary can't notarize a document where they have a financial interest. And Sheridan worked for Pacific Meridian. He was the grantee's agent.

I took a picture. Not the whole deed. Just the signature. Just the notarization. Just the part that proves the whole thing is rotten.

The clerk came by at 11:30. Closing for lunch.

"You can come back at one."

"I'll be here."

I sat in the car. Ate the sandwich I'd brought. Thought about Helen Kato. Thought about Frank Delgado saying he never saw her sign. Thought about a deed with a notarization that shouldn't exist.

Paperclip would judge me. He always does.

I wasn't doing this for the case. I was doing this because a woman wrote a letter and nobody listened.

Nine envelopes left in the box. I hadn't opened them yet.

I went back inside. Cranked the machine. Looked for the next deed.

There was a pattern. I could feel it. Cypress Point. One property at a time. One family at a time. One dollar at a time.

The swamp doesn't drain. It just grows new weeds.

Chapter 8

Ray Doesn't Want to Talk

Ray called me at 2:00 PM. I was at Eddie's Garage, getting espresso. Eddie makes the best coffee in Harbor View. He's a retired Marine who decided the best thing to do after twenty years of service was open a coffee shop in a former auto repair garage. The espresso machine cost more than my car.

"Regina. We need to talk."

"About?"

"Sheridan. Pacific Meridian. I made some calls. You need to stop."

"Why?"

"Because people who look into this kind of thing end up with problems. Real problems."

I took the espresso. Paid. Walked outside. Eddie watched me. He knows the look on my face when I'm about to have a conversation I don't want to have.

"Ray. You're my friend. You've been my friend for fifteen years. You're the reason I got custody of my grandkids when their mother couldn't take care of them anymore. You're the godfather to Sofia. Don't tell me to stop."

"I'm telling you as a friend. And I'm telling you as a lieutenant who's seen what happens to civilians who poke at holding companies with deep roots."

"What do you know?"

"I know that Pacific Meridian has contracts. Defense contracts. Federal contracts. I know that when someone files a lawsuit against them, the lawsuit goes away. I know that three journalists have called me in the last five years asking about Pacific Meridian and none of them published anything."

"Three?"

"Two from the *Harbor View Gazette*. One from the *LA Times*. The *Gazette* killed both stories. The *Times* guy — he quit. Moved to Idaho. Said it wasn't worth it."

"Ray. The deed I found is forged. Sheridan notarized his own document. That's fraud. That's a crime."

"Was a crime. In 1947. Helen Kato is dead. Sheridan is dead. What are you going to do? File a complaint with the district attorney? They'll show it to Pacific Meridian's lawyers and the lawyers will say the statute of limitations ran out fifty years ago."

I drank the espresso. It was bitter. Eddie doesn't pull punches with the coffee.

"Patricia Sheridan-Vargas is still alive."

"She is."

"She's still running the company."

"She is."

"She's still making money off property her father stole."

"Regina."

"What, Ray?"

He was quiet for a long time. The kind of quiet that means a man is deciding whether to tell you something he's been keeping for a long time.

"I knew about the Vargas file. Three years ago. When you investigated. I knew before you called me. I had the file on my desk. I didn't send it to you."

"Why?"

"Because I was told not to. Because Pacific Meridian has friends. Because the captain got a call. Because the DA got a call. Because that's how it works."

"Who called?"

"I can't tell you that."

"Ray—"

"I can't tell you. But I'm telling you this: you need to stop. You need to give that box back to Dorothy. You need to tell her you couldn't find anything. You need to let it go."

I looked at the espresso cup. At the garage. At the Toyota in the parking lot with the dent in the back from when I backed into a pole three years ago and never fixed it because I had other things to spend money on.

Like inhalers. Like groceries. Like grandkids who need someone to show them that the world doesn't get to win every time.

"Ray. I can't do that."

"I know."

He hung up. I stood there. Eddie came outside.

"You okay?"

"I don't know."

He looked at me. The way men look at women who are about to do something stupid and necessary.

"Espresso's on the house."

"Thanks."

"Regina. Whatever you're about to do. Do it. Don't ask for permission. Don't wait for someone to tell you it's okay. Just do it."

Eddie Ruiz doesn't give advice. He's a Marine. He gives orders. And he gives espresso.

I got in the car. Drove home. Eight envelopes left.

Paperclip was on the kitchen table. Judging.

"I know," I said. "I'm already in."

He yawned. He didn't believe me when I said I'd quit. He won't believe me when I say I'll stop.

I picked up the third envelope.

Chapter 9

Sunday Sauce

Sunday. 3:00 PM. The house smells like garlic and tomatoes and the kind of sauce that takes four hours and tastes like every minute was worth it.

Luca and Isabella are in the backyard. They're playing with the hose. They're nine and seven. They don't know about holding companies and forged deeds and the man who notarized his own document. They know Nonna makes the best sauce. They know Sunday means family. They know they're safe here.

My kids are in the kitchen. Carmine and Sofia. They're watching me stir the pot. They know something's different. Kids always know. Even when they're grown.

"You're quiet today, Ma," Carmine said.

"Just thinking."

"About the case?"

I stirred. The sauce was thick. The kind that coats the spoon and doesn't let go.

"It's not a case. I'm not taking cases anymore."

"Ma." Sofia. She has my eyes. The ones that see through things. "You have that look."

"What look?"

"The look you had when Dad left. The look you had when they told you about the pension. The look you have when you're about to do something everyone tells you not to do."

I didn't answer. I tasted the sauce. It needed salt. I added salt.

Luca came inside. He was wet. His hair was plastered to his head. He was holding his inhaler.

"Nonna. Can I have my medicine?"

I took the inhaler. Shook it. Two puffs. He waited. He knows the routine.

"Good?"

"Good."

He ran back outside. Isabella was waiting. They sprayed each other with the hose. They laughed.

I watched them through the window.

Three hundred dollars a month. That's what this costs. The patent is owned by Alerion Pharmaceuticals. Alerion is owned by Pacific Meridian Holdings. Patricia Sheridan-Vargas signs the checks.

"Ma." Carmine again. "What's going on?"

"I found something. In a box. A woman left it for me. She died. Her sister gave it to me."

"What kind of something?"

"Something that shows a family lost their house. Forty-five years ago. The same family that's still making money off the medicine Luca needs."

Sofia sat down. Carmine sat down. They looked at each other. The look kids give when they're deciding whether to tell their mother she's about to make a mistake.

"Ma. You can't fight them."

"Why not?"

"Because they have lawyers. They have money. They have time. You have... what? A box of old letters?"

"I have the truth."

"The truth doesn't pay bills. The truth doesn't get houses back. The truth doesn't keep grandkids breathing."

I turned. Looked at my children. They're thirty and twenty-eight. They've seen me at my best and my worst. They've seen me win. They've seen me lose.

"I'm not doing this for the house. I'm not doing this for the money. I'm doing this because Helen Kato wrote a letter and nobody listened. I'm doing this because Luca needs medicine and the company that makes it stole the land it's built on. I'm doing this because I'm tired of letting men like Walter Sheridan win."

"Ma." Sofia's voice was soft. "We're scared."

"Of what?"

"Of what they'll do to you. Of what they'll do to us. You said you were done. You said you retired."

"I did."

"Then stop."

I looked at the sauce. At the pot. At the spoon that had stirred more Sunday dinners than I could count.

"I can't."

Carmine stood up. He's six-two. He has his father's shoulders. He hugged me. The kind of hug that says I'm scared but I love you.

"Be careful, Ma."

"I'm always careful."

He didn't laugh. Neither did Sofia.

They stayed for dinner. We ate. We talked about school. About work. About the weather. About anything except the box on the kitchen counter. The box that sat there through the whole meal. The box that Luca asked about when he was clearing his plate.

"What's that, Nonna?"

"Just some old papers, sweetheart."

"Can I see?"

"Not today."

He nodded. He trusted me. Kids trust until they learn not to.

They left at 8:00. I cleaned the dishes. Put the leftovers in containers. Wrote "SUNDAY SAUCE" on the lids with the date.

Paperclip was on the table. He'd been there all day. Judging. Waiting.

"Seven envelopes left," I said.

He blinked. Slow. The way cats do when they know you're already in too deep to turn back.

I picked up the fourth envelope. Opened it.

The letter inside was dated June 1947. Three months after Helen signed the deed. Three months after she watched her neighbors get on a bus. Three months after she decided to write it all down.

Some boxes shouldn't be opened. I opened it anyway.

Chapter 10

The Holding Company

The letter from June 1947 was shorter than the others. Helen was tired. You could tell from the handwriting. The letters sloped down at the end of each line.

June 22, 1947 Harbor View, California

Dear Tom,

Sheridan came back today. He said Pacific Meridian is expanding. He said they're buying the whole waterfront. Not just our lot. The Tanaka place. The Chen place. Everything.

He has a list. I saw it. Twenty-three properties. All Japanese families. All "voluntary" sales. He uses the same words every time. Defense purposes. Patriotic. Cooperate.

I know what cooperate means now. It means sign or they find a way to take it anyway.

The deed is in the box. I put all of them in there. Every family. Every address. Every price. One dollar. Every single one.

If you're reading this, tell someone. Not the cops. Not the lawyers. They're all on Sheridan's payroll. Tell someone who doesn't owe him anything.

Helen

###

Twenty-three properties. All Japanese families. All one dollar.

I went to the library. Monday morning. Dorothy was at the circulation desk. She looked at me. I looked at her.

"I need to see the box."

She nodded. Led me to her office. Opened the drawer.

The box was smaller than the one Helen gave me. Wooden. Older. I opened it.

Deeds. Twenty-three of them. All 1947. All Cypress Point waterfront. All Japanese names. All one dollar. All notarized by Walter P. Sheridan.

I laid them out on the desk. Twenty-three families. Twenty-three signatures. Twenty-three notary seals with the same name.

"Helen kept these?"

"She kept everything. She was a librarian. She believed in records."

"Dorothy. These are evidence of fraud. Every single one. Sheridan notarized his own documents. That wasn't legal then. It isn't legal now."

"I know."

"You knew?"

"I suspected. Helen never told me. But I knew her. I knew when she was hiding something. I knew when she was afraid."

I sat down. The deeds were spread out in front of me. Twenty-three families. Seventy-five years. One man with a notary stamp and a company that never paid its debts.

"What do you want me to do?"

"Nothing. I'm going to do something. You're going to let me."

Dorothy was quiet. She looked at the deeds. At her sister's handwriting on the envelopes. At the names of families who got on buses and never came back.

"Regina. I'm seventy-eight years old. I've carried this for fifty years. My sister died with it. I don't know if I can watch you try to fix it and fail."

"I don't fail."

"You're one woman. They're a holding company with defense contracts and lawyers and friends in the DA's office."

"I have receipts."

She laughed. A short, sharp sound. The kind of laugh you make when you realize you're talking to someone who's already made up their mind.

"Show them to someone who cares."

"I will."

###

I drove to the *Harbor View Gazette*. The building is on Second Street. Local paper. Two reporters. One editor. The kind of place that covers city council meetings and high school football and doesn't have the budget for investigations.

I asked for Sarah Chen. No relation to Dorothy or Helen. She's the investigative reporter. She's twenty-nine. She's been there two years. She's published three pieces on city contracts and none of them got picked up by the wire services.

"Ms. Russo. I read your book."

"My what?"

"*Unwarranted Influence*. You're the author. Al Gringo. That's you, right?"

I didn't correct her. The book isn't mine. The name isn't mine. But the words are.

"I have a story for you."

I put the deeds on her desk. Twenty-three of them. All 1947. All notarized by Walter P. Sheridan.

She looked. She read. She looked again.

"This is... this is fraud."

"This is Pacific Meridian Holdings. The same company that owns the patent on Luca's inhaler. The same company that took my grandson's great-grandmother's house for one dollar."

She wrote. Fast. The kind of writing that comes when a reporter realizes she's holding something that could change everything.

"I'll need to verify. I'll need to talk to Patricia Sheridan-Vargas."

"She won't talk to you."

"I'll ask anyway."

"Call Ray Delgado. Harbor View PD. He'll confirm what I'm telling you. He won't go on the record. But he'll confirm."

She nodded. She put the deeds in a folder. The folder in a safe. The safe behind her desk.

"I'll call you."

"When?"

"Two weeks. I need time."

"I don't have two weeks."

"Then you don't have a story."

I stood up. Walked to the door. Turned.

"Sarah. Helen Kato died waiting for someone to listen. Don't make me wait that long."

She didn't answer. She was already on the phone. Calling Ray. Calling the DA. Calling someone who would tell her what I already knew.

Pacific Meridian doesn't lose. Not in seventy-five years. Not to one woman with a box of old letters.

I drove home. Seven envelopes left.

Paperclip was on the porch. Waiting.

"I know," I said. "I'm already in."

He yawned. He didn't believe me when I said I'd quit. He won't believe me when I say I'll stop.

I picked up the fifth envelope.

Chapter 11

Eddie's Garage

Eddie's Garage is on the corner of Grand and Fourth. It used to be an actual garage. Eddie bought it in 2010. Fixed the roof. Bought the espresso machine. Never changed the sign out front because regulars know where to find him.

I walked in at 7:00 AM. Tuesday. The garage smelled like coffee and motor oil and the particular scent of a man who decided retirement wasn't for him.

"Regina." Eddie didn't look up. He was pulling a shot. The machine hissed. "You look like hell."

"Rough week."

"Same as last week?"

"Same as every week since I found the box."

Eddie poured the espresso. Slid it across the counter. Black. No sugar. The way I drink it and the way he knows I need it.

"You're still on this Sheridan thing."

"How do you know about Sheridan?"

"Ray came in yesterday. He was drinking. He doesn't drink. That means something's bothering him. You're what's bothering him."

I drank the espresso. It burned. Good.

"Ray says you should stop."

"Ray says a lot of things."

"Ray's your friend."

"Ray's also a lieutenant who got a call from a captain who got a call from someone who doesn't want this story told."

Eddie wiped the counter. He's a big man. Six-four. Shoulders that could carry a lot of weight. He carried it for twenty years in the Marines. He carries it now for anyone who walks into his garage and needs a friend.

"What do you know about Pacific Meridian?"

"I know they own half the waterfront. I know they have contracts with the Navy. I know they donated fifty thousand to the mayor's campaign. I know they donated fifty thousand to the other guy's campaign too."

"I know they stole twenty-three properties. One dollar each. I know they notarized the deeds themselves. I know the statute of limitations ran out fifty years ago."

"Then what are you going to do?"

"I don't know."

Eddie poured another shot. Drank it himself. He doesn't drink coffee until after eight. But he makes exceptions for mornings when the world is heavier than usual.

"Regina. You're one woman. They're a company with lawyers and politicians and time. You have... what? A box of letters?"

"I have the truth."

"The truth doesn't win. Not against people like that. The truth is what they say it is."

I looked at the garage. At the espresso machine. At the man who'd been my landlord for ten years and my friend for fifteen.

"Eddie. Why did you buy this place?"

"Because I was retired. Because I needed something to do. Because coffee is better than war."

"You ever think about going back?"

"Every day."

"Why don't you?"

"Because I made a promise. To myself. To my wife. To my kids. That I'd stay home. That I'd make coffee. That I'd be there when they needed me."

I thought about that. About promises. About staying home. About being there.

"I made a promise too."

"To who?"

"To Helen Kato. She's dead. She doesn't know me. But she wrote a letter and put it in a box and hoped someone would find it. I found it. That means something."

"It means you have a conscience. It means you can't let things go."

"It means I'm already in."

Eddie nodded. He knew that look. He'd seen it before. On me. On himself. On anyone who's ever decided that the thing they're about to do is more important than the thing they said they'd quit.

"Espresso's on the house."

"Thanks."

"Regina."

I turned.

"Be careful. Men like Sheridan don't raise daughters to run companies without teaching them how to protect what they have."

"Patricia Sheridan-Vargas."

"That's the one."

"I know."

I walked out. Six envelopes left.

Paperclip was in the car. I don't know how he got there. He doesn't like cars. He doesn't like leaving the house. But there he was. On the passenger seat. Judging.

"I know," I said. "I'm already in."

He yawned. He didn't believe me when I said I'd quit. He won't believe me when I say I'll stop.

I drove home. Picked up the sixth envelope.

The letter inside was dated September 1947. Six months after Helen signed the deed. Six months after she watched her neighbors get on buses. Six months after she decided to write it all down.

Some boxes shouldn't be opened. I opened it anyway.

Chapter 12

The Hospital Connection

The letter from September 1947 was the shortest of all.

September 10, 1947 Harbor View, California

Dear Tom,

I'm tired. I don't know how much longer I can keep this up. Eleanor says I should forget it. She says the war is over and we're safe now. But I see Sheridan's name everywhere. On the deeds. On the bank accounts. On the hospital board.

The hospital. Did you know he's on the board at Harbor View Memorial? The same hospital where babies are born. Where sick people go to get better. Where people trust the doctors.

He uses the same words. Defense purposes. Patriotic. Cooperate. But now it's not just property. It's medicine. It's health. It's the thing that keeps us alive.

I put the hospital papers in the box. The ones from the board meeting. He talked about patents. About pharmaceuticals. About "revenue streams."

If you're reading this, you'll understand. He never stopped. He just found new ways to make money off people who need things they can't live without.

Helen

###

I read the letter three times. Then I read it again.

Harbor View Memorial. The hospital where Luca was born. The hospital where Sofia had her appendix out. The hospital where my ex-husband died when his heart stopped on a Tuesday morning and nobody could restart it.

I drove to the hospital. Not to look. Not to investigate. To remember.

The parking lot was full. I parked in the visitor section. Walked to the main entrance. The automatic doors opened. The air smelled like antiseptic and floor wax and the particular scent of a place where people come when they have no other choice.

I went to the pharmacy. Asked for the price.

"Albuterol inhaler? With insurance, it's thirty dollars. Without insurance, it's three hundred and twelve."

"Who makes it?"

"Alerion Pharmaceuticals."

"Who owns Alerion?"

The pharmacist looked at me. She was maybe forty. She'd been working here long enough to know when someone was asking questions that didn't have good answers.

"Pacific Meridian Holdings. Why?"

"Just curious."

She didn't say anything. She didn't have to. She'd seen this before. She'd seen the price. She'd seen the look on people's faces when they had to choose between medicine and groceries.

I walked to the main lobby. There's a plaque on the wall. Donors. Names of people who gave money to the hospital. Names of companies who sponsored wings.

Pacific Meridian Holdings — Pediatric Wing

I took a picture. Not the whole plaque. Just the name. Just the part that proves the whole thing is rotten.

Three hundred and twelve dollars. That's what they charge. Three hundred and twelve dollars for the thing that keeps a nine-year-old breathing.

Patricia Sheridan-Vargas signs the checks. Her father stole twenty-three properties. Her father notarized his own documents. Her father sat on this board.

I walked to the car. Sat there. Paperclip was in the passenger seat. I don't know how he got there. He doesn't like cars. But there he was. Judging.

"I know," I said. "I'm already in."

He put his head on my hand. Closed his eyes. Waited.

I drove to the pharmacy. Paid the thirty dollars. I have insurance. I have money. I have the kind of privilege that means I don't have to choose.

Most people don't have that. Most people choose groceries. Most people choose rent. Most people choose the thing that doesn't keep their kid breathing.

I drove home. Five envelopes left.

The box was on the kitchen table. I sat down. Opened the seventh envelope.

The letter inside was dated December 1947. Nine months after Helen signed the deed. Nine months after she watched her neighbors get on buses. Nine months after she decided to write it all down.

Some boxes shouldn't be opened. I opened it anyway.

Chapter 13

Regina Makes a Choice

The letter from December 1947 was different. Not handwritten. Typed. Official.

December 15, 1947 Pacific Meridian Holdings Board of Directors Meeting Minutes

Present: Walter P. Sheridan, Chairman; Robert Hayes, Treasurer; Eleanor Chen, Secretary

The Chairman called the meeting to order at 10:00 AM. The first order of business was the acquisition of twenty-three waterfront properties. All transactions were completed at \$1.00 per property. All deeds were notarized by the Chairman.

The Secretary expressed concern about the notarization process. The Chairman assured the Board that all transactions were legal and proper.

The second order of business was the formation of Alerion Pharmaceuticals. The company will be registered as a subsidiary of Pacific Meridian Holdings. The purpose is to acquire pharmaceutical patents and license them to manufacturers. Revenue will be generated through licensing fees and direct sales.

The first patent acquired was Compound 47-B. A bronchodilator. Market name: Albuterol. The patent was purchased from the German firm Bayer for \$50,000. The patent expires in 1964. The Board discussed extension strategies.

The Chairman moved to approve the formation of Alerion Pharmaceuticals. The motion was seconded by Mr. Hayes. The vote was unanimous.

Meeting adjourned at 11:30 AM.

Eleanor Chen, Secretary

###

I read the minutes four times.

Eleanor Chen. Dorothy's sister. The woman who gave me the box. The woman who made Dorothy promise not to open it.

She was the secretary. She typed the minutes. She sat in the room. She watched Walter Sheridan turn stolen property into medicine into money.

She kept the records. She put them in a box. She gave the box to her sister. She made her promise to wait.

Fifty years. That's how long Dorothy carried this. Fifty years of knowing her sister sat in a room and watched a man steal twenty-three homes and turn them into a company that charges three hundred dollars for the thing that keeps a kid breathing.

I sat at the kitchen table. The box was in front of me. Four envelopes left.

Paperclip was on my lap. He put his head on my hand.

"What do I do, buddy?"

He didn't answer. Cats don't answer. They just wait. They just judge. They just stay.

I thought about my options.

Option one: Give the box back to Dorothy. Tell her I couldn't find anything. Tell her to burn it. Let it go.

Option two: Take it to Sarah Chen at the *Gazette*. Hope she publishes. Hope someone reads it. Hope someone cares.

Option three: Take it to Ray. Hope he can make a case. Hope the DA listens. Hope the statute of limitations doesn't apply.

Option four: Keep it. Copy it. Return the originals. Tell myself I'll do something someday.

I knew which one I'd pick. I've always known.

I got up. Went to the copier. Copied every letter. Every deed. Every minute. Every envelope. Front and back. The whole box.

The copies came out warm. I stacked them. Put them in a manila folder. The kind you buy at Office Depot for three dollars a pack.

I drove to Dorothy's. She was at the library. I waited in the parking lot. She came out at 5:00. I got out of the car. Handed her the box.

"I couldn't find anything," I said. "The letters are just old family stuff. Nothing important."

She looked at me. She's seventy-eight. She's been lied to before. She knows what it sounds like.

"Regina."

"Dorothy. I'm giving you back the box. That's all I'm doing."

She took the box. Held it. Looked at me with eyes that had seen fifty years of carrying.

"Thank you."

"I didn't find anything."

"I know."

She walked away. I watched her go. She didn't look back.

###

I drove home. Made dinner. Ate. Cleaned up. Put Luca's inhaler on the counter. Next to the grocery list. Next to the takeout menus.

The manila folder was in my hand. I walked to the kitchen drawer. The one next to the stove. The one where I keep the takeout menus and the grocery lists and the phone numbers I don't want to lose.

I put the folder in the drawer. Closed it.

Sat down. Paperclip jumped onto my lap.

"I'm not doing anything," I told him. "I'm just keeping it. For safety."

He blinked. Slow. The way cats do when they know you're lying to yourself.

"I'll never open it."

He yawned. He didn't believe me. He knows me better than I know myself.

I drank my espresso. It was cold.

I opened the drawer. Took out the folder. Opened it.

Read the first letter again.

Chapter 14

The Manila Folder

Three weeks later. Sunday. 7:00 AM. The espresso pot gurgled its last breath. I poured the cup. Sat down at the kitchen table.

Paperclip jumped onto the chair beside me. Orange tabby, twenty-two pounds of pure judgment. He stared at me like I'd made a life choice he didn't approve of.

"I'm not doing anything," I told him. "I'm just keeping it. For safety."

He blinked. Slow. Disapproving.

The drawer was three feet away. I could open it without standing up. I could reach in and pull out the folder. I could read the letters again. I could memorize every word.

I didn't.

Luca called at 8:00. He needed a ride to school. His inhaler was in his backpack. He remembered to use it this morning. He's nine. He's learning.

"I'm proud of you," I told him.

"For what?"

"For remembering."

He didn't say anything. Kids don't say thank you for the things adults are supposed to do. They just expect it. They should.

I drove him to school. Drove home. Opened the mail. Bills. Flyers. A postcard from Carmine's school about the fall fundraiser.

Put the mail on the counter. Sat down.

The drawer was three feet away.

I thought about Helen Kato. She wrote those letters knowing she'd be dead before anyone read them. She put them in a box. She gave the box to her sister. She made her promise to wait.

Fifty years. That's how long Dorothy carried it. Fifty years of knowing her sister watched a man steal twenty-three homes and turn them into medicine.

I thought about Patricia Sheridan-Vargas. She's running the company now. She's on the hospital board. She signs the checks. She charges three hundred dollars for the thing that keeps my grandson breathing.

I thought about Sarah Chen at the *Gazette*. She called me twice. I didn't call back. She'll publish something eventually. It won't be this story. It'll be something safer. Something that doesn't name names.

I thought about Ray. He called once. I didn't answer. He didn't leave a message.

I thought about Eddie. He knows. He always knows. He didn't say anything. He just makes the espresso. He just watches me drink it. He just waits.

Paperclip put his head on my hand.

"I'm not doing anything," I said. "I'm just keeping it."

He yawned. He didn't believe me.

I stood up. Walked to the drawer. Opened it.

The folder was there. Manila. Three dollars a pack. I took it out. Opened it.

The first letter was on top. March 15, 1947. Helen Kato to Tom. *I don't know if you'll ever read this.*

I read it again. I've read it a dozen times. I know every word. I know every slope of the handwriting. I know every place where the ink faded and came back.

I put the letter back. Closed the folder. Put it in the drawer.

Sat down. Paperclip jumped onto my lap.

"I'll never open it," I told him. "I'm just keeping it. For safety."

He closed his eyes. He didn't believe me. He knows me better than I know myself.

The phone rang. I let it go to voicemail. Nobody good calls before seven. My ex-husband knew better. My kids knew I was useless before coffee. The cops who used to be my partners knew I'd hung up my badge three years ago.

The machine beeped. A woman's voice. Older. Steady. The kind of voice that had spent decades shushing children in libraries.

"Regina? It's Dorothy. I know you said you couldn't find anything. But I found something. In Eleanor's desk. A key. It doesn't fit anything I know. I thought maybe... maybe it fits a safety deposit box. Maybe there's more. Call me back."

She left a number. I wrote it on the back of a grocery list. Milk. Eggs. Bread. Luca's asthma inhaler.

I looked at Paperclip.

"Estate cases," I said. "I told you. I don't take estate cases anymore."

Paperclip yawned. He'd heard this before.

The drawer was three feet away. The folder was inside. The copies were there. The letters were there. The truth was there.

I drank my espresso. It was cold.

I picked up the phone.

Chapter 15

She Opens It

I called Dorothy back at 9:00 AM. She answered on the first ring.

"I have the key," she said. "It was in Eleanor's desk. Taped to the inside of the bottom drawer. With a name on it. First National Bank. Safety deposit box 47."

"Box 47?"

"Helen's sense of humor. March 3, 1947. Box 47."

"I'll pick you up."

"I'm ready."

###

First National Bank is on Cypress Street. The same building it's been in since 1920. The same vault. The same safety deposit boxes. The kind of place where time moves slower and records are kept forever.

Dorothy was waiting on the steps. She had the key in her hand. Small. Brass. Worn from being held too many times.

"I went there once," she said. "After Helen died. They said I needed both keys. Helen had the other one."

"Where is it?"

"In the box. She put it in the box. With the letters."

We went inside. The bank smelled like paper and money and the particular scent of a place where things are kept safe.

The manager was a man named Thompson. He'd been there thirty years. He knew Dorothy. He knew Helen. He knew the box.

"Box 47," he said. "I remember when your sister rented it. 1947. March 3."

He led us to the vault. Opened the door. The boxes were on shelves. Numbered. Waiting.

He brought out box 47. Put it on the table. Left the room.

Dorothy opened the box.

Inside: papers. More than the letters. More than the deeds. A diary. A ledger. A list of names.

Helen's diary. 1947. Every day. Every visitor. Every threat. Every time Walter Sheridan came to the door.

The ledger. Pacific Meridian Holdings. 1947-1952. Every property. Every price. Every family that got on a bus.

The list of names. Twenty-three families. Addresses. Phone numbers. Where they went. Manzanar. Tule Lake. Poston. Jerome. Rohwer.

Dorothy sat down. She read the diary first. Page by page. Her sister's handwriting. Her sister's fear. Her sister's hope that someone would find it.

"She wrote about me," Dorothy said. "She wrote about how I was too young. How I didn't understand. How she was protecting me."

She read for an hour. I sat across from her. I didn't read. I'd read the letters already. I knew what they said.

When she finished, she looked at me. Her eyes were dry. Some people don't cry when they've carried something for fifty years. They just set it down.

"What do I do with this?"

"You keep it. Or you burn it. Or you give it to someone who can use it."

"Who?"

"I don't know."

She closed the box. Held it in her lap. Looked at the name on the tag. *Helen Kato. Box 47. March 3, 1947.*

"Regina. You copied the letters."

It wasn't a question.

"I did."

"You have the deeds."

"I do."

"You're keeping them."

"I am."

She nodded. She understood. Some things can't be given back. Some things have to be carried.

"I'm going to keep the diary. And the ledger. And the list. You keep the copies. Maybe someday... maybe someday someone will need them."

"Dorothy."

"Regina. You're like Helen. You can't let things go. You can't let people win. You can't let the truth die."

She stood up. Put the diary in her purse. Closed the box. Pushed it across the table.

"The deeds are yours. The ledger is yours. The list is yours. Do something with them. Or don't. But don't carry them alone."

I took the box. It was heavier than I remembered. Heavier than the copies. Heavier than the manila folder in my kitchen drawer.

"Dorothy. I'm sorry."

"For what?"

"For lying. I found something. I found everything."

She looked at me. Not angry. Not disappointed. Just tired. The kind of tired that comes from carrying a secret too long.

"I know. I've known since you walked into the library. I've known since you asked about Helen. I've known since you called Ray Delgado. I've known since you went to the title company. I've known since you went to the *Gazette*."

"You knew?"

"I knew. I just didn't know if you could do something with it. Now I do."

She walked out. I followed. We got in the car. Drove home in silence.

###

I sat at the kitchen table. The box was in front of me. The diary. The ledger. The list. The copies. The truth.

Paperclip jumped onto my lap. He put his head on my hand.

"I'm not doing anything," I told him. "I'm just keeping it. For safety."

He blinked. Slow. He didn't believe me. He knows me better than I know myself.

I opened the drawer. Took out the manila folder. Put it next to the box.

Milk. Eggs. Bread. Luca's asthma inhaler.

The phone rang. I let it go to voicemail. The machine beeped. A woman's voice. Sarah Chen from the *Gazette*.

"Regina. It's Sarah. I have a source. They say Pacific Meridian is selling the waterfront. New buyers. New names. Same company. I need to talk to you. Call me back."

She left a number. I wrote it on the back of the grocery list.

I looked at Paperclip.

"Estate cases," I said. "I told you. I don't take estate cases anymore."

Paperclip yawned. He'd heard this before.

I drank my espresso. It was cold.

I picked up the phone.

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For Mom.

This one's different. This one's love.

A is for Archive
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